Problem Clarity *Worksheet.*

One page to separate the symptom from the problem, before you spend money or months on a fix. About twenty minutes, on your own or with one colleague.

Why this helps

Most stalled projects are not short on effort. The first fix went after the symptom people could see, not the cause underneath. Taking a few minutes to reframe the problem, and to test that reframe before a big investment, is one of the simplest ways to avoid solving the wrong one.

How to use it

1 **Write the problem the way you would say it today.**
Do not polish it. The everyday version shows what you are assuming.

2 **Sort what you know from what you assume.**
Facts are things you have seen, counted, or heard directly. Everything else is a guess worth checking.

3 **Look at it from the side of the people it affects.**
Who experiences this? What are they trying to get done when it happens?

4 **Ask what it is a symptom of.**
Ask “why does that happen?” three times. Stop when the answer is something you could change.

5 **Rewrite the problem in one sentence.**
Name who, what they cannot do, why, and what it costs. If you cannot fill every part, that gap is your next question.

6 **Choose one small test for the next two weeks.**
Something cheap and quick that would show whether your rewrite is right.

> **Example**
> Before: “Our workshop sign-ups are low. We need more marketing.”
>
> After: “Busy owners who find us on Instagram cannot tell which workshop fits them, so they leave without registering, which costs us people who were ready to come.” Test: add three short “this is for you if” lines to the page for two weeks and compare registrations.

The reframing steps draw on Thomas Wedell-Wedellsborg, “Are You Solving the Right Problems?” Harvard Business Review, January–February 2017, hbr.org/2017/01/are-you-solving-the-right-problems. The example is illustrative.

1 · THE PROBLEM, AS I WOULD SAY IT TODAY

2A · WHAT I KNOW

Seen, counted, or heard directly

2B · WHAT I AM ASSUMING

Guesses worth checking

3 · THE PEOPLE IT AFFECTS

Who experiences it, and what are they trying to get done when it happens?

4 · WHAT IS THIS A SYMPTOM OF?

Why does that happen? Why? Why? Stop at something you could change.

5 · THE PROBLEM IN ONE SENTENCE

[Who] cannot [do what] because [cause], which costs [what].

6 · MY TWO-WEEK TEST

What I will try, with whom, and what result would tell me I named it right

WHERE DOES THIS SIT? CHECK THE CLOSEST.

- ☐ Strategy and positioning
- ☐ Partnership development
- ☐ Program and service design
- ☐ Hands-on implementation

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